administration's foreign policy priorities begin to include the Iranian threat. The first step on this path needed to be a visit by Obama to Moscow and a proposal to Putin that in exchange for Russian support for sanctions against Iran, the United States would retract its intentions to deploy a missile defense system in eastern Europe. Dealing with the Israeli-Palestinian conflict would be much simpler *after* the Iranian threat had been dealt with.

I never received confirmation that the letter had reached its destination. But on July 9, 2009, the *New York Times* noted that during a visit to Russia "President Obama today offered to scrap plans for a missile defense shield in Eastern Europe if Russia helped to stop Iran developing a nuclear bomb" and that he told graduating students of the New Economic School in Moscow, "I want us to work together on a missile defense architecture that makes us all safer. But if the threat from Iran's nuclear and ballistic missiles programs is eliminated, the driving force for missile defense in Europe will be eliminated. That is in our mutual interest."

The Russian response to Obama's proposals was only lukewarm. From then until 2010, the United States abandoned President Bush's original missile defense plan in eastern Europe, though the Russians did not really join the American-European camp against Iran's nuclearization. It can only be assumed that the price that the United States was willing to pay the Russians for joining their efforts did not satisfy them. What the Russians want from the United States in exchange for their joining the anti-Iranian Western front is the recognition of their status as an equal power. (In the years that followed, the United States and Russia—together with other powers—cooperated in putting pressure on Iran, including sanctions, which led to the signing of the nuclear agreement in 2015. However, the agreement does not fully reflect the initial demands that the United States presented to Iran, and various actors, particularly Israel, regard it as a capitulation to Iran.)

Russia is apparently not worried about a nuclear neighbor to its south because its own nuclear power—today and in the future—will deter Iran from threatening it, since Russia can easily wipe Iran off the map altogether. Russia does seem to be concerned about Iran's imperial ambitions, which will be bolstered by military nuclear capability, at least in the Middle East, but that is not enough to convince it to join the United States. Perhaps the Russians have some other hidden consideration? An Israeli attack on Iran's nuclear facilities would certainly serve Russian interests: